
Sexual Orientation

Ms. Mitchell

Sex/Gender/Sexual orientation,
what's the difference?

Why is it important to
differentiate the three?

Understanding Sexual Orientation

Sexual orientation — a person's sexual or romantic attractions to the same sex, the other sex, both or neither

Heterosexual/straight — attraction to the other sex

Lesbian — women attracted to women

Gay — men attracted to men

Understanding Sexual Orientation

Bisexual — attraction to men and/or women, not necessarily equally or at the same time

LGBTQIA+ (lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, queer/questioning, intersex, asexual) — umbrella term for the social movement supporting sexual minority rights

Queer/questioning — individuals not identifying as heterosexual and/or exploring same-sex attraction

Understanding Sexual Orientation

Attraction usually involves both sex and gender

Non-heterosexual orientations are often stigmatized

- How do new norms impact stigma?

Development of sexual orientation before adulthood

- Biology
- Culture
- Social

Understanding Sexual Orientation

Sexual orientation begins in childhood, develops over life

- Middle childhood = sensitive period.
- Becomes "second nature"
- How would this impact someone as they are learning about sexuality in adolescence?

The Spectrum of Sexual Orientation

Sexual orientation as a spectrum

- Explains sexual diversity.
- Variations of nonexclusive orientations
- Sexual attractions and desires may change over time

The Spectrum of Sexual Orientation

Pansexual — sexual, emotional, romantic, or spiritual attraction to others regardless of sex, gender, or orientation

Asexuality — no notable sexual attraction to others; romantic relationships may still occur
NOT

- Celibacy
- Abstinence
- Low sexual desire.

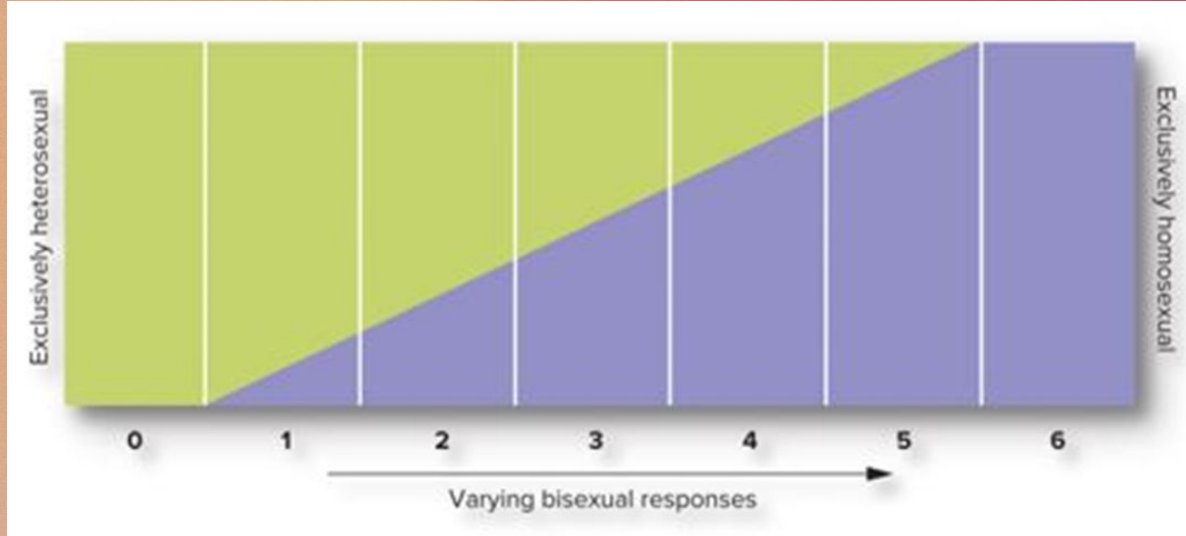
The Spectrum of Sexual Orientation

Kinsey scale (1948) — measured sexual orientation as a spectrum

- Found “pure” heterosexuals or LGBTQ individuals are rare
- Populations show significant individual differences

Figure 10.1 The Kinsey scale

The Kinsey scale emphasizes sexual behavior and attraction as expressions of sexual orientation. It is split into three ranges: 0–1 indicates exclusive or predominant heterosexuality, 2–4 indicates equal or “more than incidental” homosexuality and heterosexuality, and 5–6 indicates “exclusive or predominant homosexuality.”



The Spectrum of Sexual Orientation

Klein scale (1978) — measures sexual orientation diversity and fluidity

- Included sexual feelings, fantasies, identities, and behavior

The Gap Between Sexual Attraction and Behavior

Gap between sexual attractions and expressed sexual behavior.

Three dimensions

- Behavior
- Desire
- Identity

Sexual orientation is multidimensional

Figure 10.2 The gap between desire, behavior, and identity in men and women



Sources of Sexual Orientation: Genetic Sources

Genetic Sources

- Genetic
- Prenatal
- Postnatal
- Interactive biopsychosocial

Genome -> fetal development.

Environment -> gene expression (epigenetics)

Sources of Sexual Orientation: Genetic Sources

Having a gene does not guarantee the trait will appear

Twin studies — research comparing twins to determine nature vs. nurture influences

- Monozygotic ("identical") vs dizygotic ("fraternal") twins — identical twins are more similar, helping separate effects of genes, culture, and unique experiences

Sources of Sexual Orientation:

Genetic Sources

Research shows that if one identical twin is gay, the other is most likely to be gay, too.

- 70% of sexual orientation comes from social factors
- Genes + environment

-> genetics impact sexual orientation, but cannot discredit the amount of social influence a person experiences

Sources of Sexual Orientation: Prenatal Development

Births affect sexual orientation

- Brain sensitivity to hormones before birth may influence later sexual attractions
- **Birth order effect** — having older brothers may increase the likelihood of a younger brother developing a same-gender orientation

Sources of Sexual Orientation: Interactive Biopsychosocial Sources

Interactive biopsychosocial approach — theory suggesting biological, psychological, and social factors interact to shape sexual attractions and orientation

- Women vs Men

Sexual Socialization and Compulsory Heterosexuality

Children's sexual expression — reflects cultural rules about attraction and orientation

Compulsory heterosexuality — social pressure to date the other gender, marry, and have children, regardless of orientation

- How does this relate to heteronormativity?

Sexual Individuality and Sexual Orientation

Sexual individuality + sexual orientation = sexual well-being.

Sexual individuality — rooted in bodily experiences, biology, family, and sexual socialization

- Attractions
- Arousal
- Awareness grows with age

Same-Sex Behavior Variations Across Cultures

Three areas of sexual behavior expression

- Age difference
- Societal impact???
- Gender difference
- Role difference

Same-Sex Behavior Variations Across Cultures

Two-spirit — among Great Plains Indigenous peoples, individuals may take on gender roles different from their assigned sex at birth

Transvestite — someone with an interest in wearing clothing typical of the other gender. (Not to be confused with transvestism)

Men Who Have Sex With Men (MSM)

Men who have sex with men (MSM) — men who live socially as heterosexuals, married to or date women, but also have sex with men

- Cultural label, not an orientation
- Emerging during the HIV epidemic of the 1980s

Being on the down low (BODL) — term used in African American communities for men who hide their sexual orientation

- Hostility toward LGBTQIA
- HIV ris

Female Sexual Fluidity

Sexual fluidity — a form of sexual expression that is situation-dependent and shaped more by individual characteristics than by anatomy

- More socially acceptable for women

LGBTQ Identity Discrimination and Stigma

Just as racism affects people of color, anti-LGBTQ bias can shape the development and expression of sexual orientation

- **Stigma** — extreme disapproval of someone who deviates from social norms

Sexual Prejudice, Homophobia, and Homonegativity

Sexual prejudice — irrational hatred directed at people because of their sexual orientation or behavior

Homophobia — irrational fear of or discrimination against same-gender sexuality or LGBTQIA+ individuals

- Aggression and violence.

Homonegativity — subtle negative social perceptions or behaviors toward LGBTQIA+ people or those suspected of same-gender sexuality

Hate Crimes

Hate crime — an act of aggression or hatred targeted at someone because of religion, race, or sexual orientation

- Matthew Shepard and James Byrd, Jr., Hate Crimes Prevention Act (2009) provides legal protection for people targeted because of sexual orientation, gender, or disability

Being Out—Steps Toward Well-Being

Being or Coming out — disclosing a sexual orientation to the people who truly matter

What are some hesitations with coming out?

Questions?
